



The Fool's Court

A trick-taking game of promises, for four players

FOUR PLAYERS · 45 MINUTES

TWELVE NIGHTS TO A SEASON

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IN THIS BOX

60 agent cards — four kinds, ranked 1–15
 22 Whisper cards, 7 of them burdens
 4 quick reference cards
 This sheet

1 Overview

Four nobles compete for the ear of the monarch over a series of **nights**. At the start of each night every player privately promises how many **audiences** they will win, then plays to reach that number *exactly*: overshooting is punished as surely as falling short. A season is **twelve nights**; whoever holds the most favour at the end wins.

A *hand* is a **night**. A *promise* is a **pledge**. A *trick* is an **audience**. The trump suit is the **sway**. Points are **favour**. The dealer is the **steward**.

2 The deck

Sixty cards: four kinds of agent, each ranked **1 to 15**. Rank 15 is the most influential, rank 1 the least.

AGENT	MARK	PROMISES
Fool	cap and bells	0

Merchant	a balance	1
Lover	a rose	2
Assassin	a dagger	3

An agent's **kind** decides what it promises on an errand (5); its **rank** decides whether it wins an audience (6). The two never interact.

3 Seating and the course of a night

Four players sit in a fixed order; play and the deal go **clockwise**. One player is the **steward** for the night, and the stewardship passes one seat left after every night.

1. The steward deals **15 cards** to each player, exhausting the deck.
2. If Whispers are in use, each player looks at their hand and chooses whether to take one, unread and for nothing (4).
3. Each player sends **four agents** out on errands, face down. Their kinds are that player's pledge (5).
4. The player to the steward's left opens the first of **eleven audiences** (6).
5. Errands and Whispers are revealed; favour is scored (7).
6. The number of pledges kept sets the sway for the next night (8).

After twelve nights the season ends and the most favour wins (9).

4 The Whispers [OPTIONAL]

Optional. A season played without them is a complete game. The **22 Whispers** are shuffled face down each night. After the deal and **before any pledge is made**, each eligible player may look at their own hand and then take one Whisper or go without.

The monarch does not confide in whoever is winning. Only a player whose favour is *strictly* less than the highest

at the table may take one, so on the first night nobody is offered a word.

Taking one **costs nothing**, but it is taken **unread**. **7 of the 22 are burdens**, which cost rather than pay, so a word is a gamble rather than a formality. A burden is framed in oxblood under a broken seal and signed as one; but every Whisper is identical face down, and a player who took one need not say which.

A Whisper bends how that player's favour is counted, or restricts which agents they may send, or both, and stays **private** until the night ends. A restriction is binding, but a demand a hand cannot obey — an Assassin required while holding none — is **waived**. No two players hold the same word on the same night, and a Whisper never changes the rules of play in 6. All 22 are listed in 10.

5 Making a pledge

Before any card is played, each player selects **four cards** from their hand and places them face down. These are that player's **errands**.

A player's **pledge** is the sum of the errand values of the four cards sent, by kind. **Rank is disregarded entirely**: a Fool of 15 promises as little as a Fool of 1. Errands stay face down and **out of play**, so eleven cards remain in each hand and **eleven audiences** are contested.

A pledge is **not capped**: four Assassins pledge twelve, more than the eleven available, and cannot be kept. Nothing forbids it. All errands are revealed together when the night ends; until then no player knows another's pledge, nor what has left their hand.

6 Playing the night

The player to the steward's left **opens** the first audience with any card, including one of the ruling kind.

Play goes clockwise. Each player must **answer in kind** — play a card of the same kind as the one that opened the audience — if they hold one. A player holding none may play anything.

The audience is won by the **highest-ranked card of the opening kind**, unless a card of the **ruling kind** (8) was played, in which case the highest of those wins instead. A card of neither kind can never win, whatever its rank.

The winner opens the next. Eleven audiences are played, exhausting every hand.

7 Winning favour

At the end of the night each player compares the audiences they won against the pledge they made.

RESULT	FAVOUR
Pledge kept exactly	2 for every audience won
Pledge missed, high or low	1 for every audience won, less 2 for every audience off the pledge
Pledged nothing, won nothing	8
Pledged nothing, won any	-8, however many

Examples.

Pledged 4, won 4	+8
Pledged 5, won 4	+2
Pledged 3, won 6	0
Pledged 2, won 0	-4
Pledged 0, won 0	+8
Pledged 0, won 3	-8
Pledged 11, won 11	+22

Being *wrong* costs 2 favour per audience in either direction, so there is no advantage in under-promising and overshooting. The

only good outcome is the exact one.

8 Who holds sway

One kind may **hold sway** for a night, outranking every other kind when audiences are decided (6). No player chooses it: it follows from how the *previous* night went. The first night of a season is always **No Sway**. Counted from pledges kept **exactly**, and known to everyone before pledges are made.

PLEDGES KEPT	SWAY NEXT NIGHT
0	♠ Fools
1	♠ Merchants
2	♠ Lovers
3	♠ Assassins
4	No Sway

9 Winning the season

A season is exactly **twelve nights**. There is no target score and no early finish: the court sits twelve times and then rises. The twelfth is **Twelfth Night**, the feast of misrule; the stewardship will have passed three full times round the table, so every player deals exactly three nights.

The player with the most favour after Twelfth Night wins. Level totals are decided, in order, by: more favour won on Twelfth Night; then the higher pledge that night; then the higher combined rank of the four errands sent that night.

10 The Whispers in full OPTIONAL

All 22 words, of which the last 7 — marked ♦ — are **burdens**. The rules governing them are in 4.

WHAT YOU MAY SEND

Blackmailed. At least one Assassin must go out. Keep your pledge for +6.

Sworn to Silence. No Assassin may go out. Keep your pledge for +3.

The Smitten. No Lover may go out. Keep your pledge for +3.

The Audited. Send two Merchants and two Fools, which pledges exactly 2. Keep it for +4.

HOW YOUR RESULT IS SCORED

The Debtor. A kept pledge of 2 or fewer earns nothing; keep 3 or more for +3.

All or Nothing. Keep your pledge for double favour. Break it and lose 3, whatever else you did.

The Cautious Clerk. You cannot lose favour this night, nor gain more than 7.

HOW YOU COMPARE TO THE TABLE

The Bold. +6 if your pledge is the highest at the table, outright.

The Meek. -3 if your pledge is the lowest or tied for lowest. Keep it for +4.

The Kingmaker. Keep your pledge and take +2 for every other noble who broke theirs.

The Favourite. +6 if you win more audiences than any other noble, outright.

The Wallflower. +6 if you win fewer audiences than any other noble, outright.

HOW YOU WIN AUDIENCES

Sworn to the Fool. +3 favour for every audience you take with a Fool.

INVERSION AND MISDIRECTION

The Contrarian. Your pledge counts the audiences you will NOT win. Keep it for +2.

The Understudy. You are scored against the pledge of the noble on your right, not your own. Take +3 for the trouble, and +5 more if you match it.

BURDENS

The Condemned. Break your pledge and lose a further 3. ♦

The Scapegoat. -2 for every other noble who keeps their pledge, to a limit of 4. ♦

In Disgrace. Favour you gain tonight is halved. Favour you lose is not. ♦

The Watched. Your errands are laid face up as soon as they are sent. ♦

Marked for the Blade. -2 for every audience you take with an Assassin. ♦

Out of Favour. A kept pledge of 4 or more earns you nothing. ♦

Called Out. -5 if you win more audiences than the noble on your right. ♦